



THE INSTITUTE OF
MASTERS
of WINE

Practical Report

2021 Stage 2 MW exam

Practical Exam Chair: Peter Marks MW.....	2
Paper one report: Paper Chair, Peter Mitchell MW.....	4
Question 1.....	5
Question 2.....	5
Question 3.....	5
Question 4.....	6
Paper two report: Paper Chair, Lisa Perrotti-Brown MW.....	7
Question 1.....	7
Question 2.....	8
Question 3.....	8
Question 4.....	8
Paper three report: Paper Chair, Ulf Sjödin MW.....	9
Question 1.....	10
Question 2.....	10
Question 3.....	11

Practical Exam Chair: Peter Marks MW

After a one-year hiatus, 101 candidates sat for the 2021 Practical Exam with only 8 achieving an overall pass. This is an 8% pass rate compared to the 15% pass rate in 2019, and 14% in 2018. No doubt, this is disappointing news to candidates and a concern for the exam team as we attempt to not only mark papers honestly but positively in order to give candidates the best opportunity to pass. There is no simple formula to passing the practical exam so long as candidates demonstrate good tasting ability, sound logic and deductive reasoning, and show confidence in their answers.

Unfortunately, too few candidates displayed these traits, as more than half the candidates failed to achieve an overall mark of C or higher. One must wonder if the crush of the pandemic resulted in a lack of preparation or pent-up anxiety triggered stress to overtake one's confidence. It is obvious that this had the greatest impact on Paper 1 as only 7% of candidates passed this paper. Paper 1 was no more challenging than Paper 2 (18% pass rate) or Paper 3 (15% pass rate) which suggests some candidates needed a day to settle into exam mode.

It is important to mention here that the grade boundaries changed in 2020. Candidates who have taken the exam before should remember this. The difference between a D (50-54%), or even an F (anything up to 45%), and a B (65-69%) is not as wide as it was previously. So, some of the marks awarded may not have been as low as candidates perceived. The reason for the change was to give a clearer signal of the candidate's progress towards a pass mark. Every MW student has bad tasting days, but any candidate who received 3 F's should consider carefully taking time out before re-sitting the exam.

Here are some overall themes to this year's exam papers which are important to highlight.

Identification seemed no better or worse than in the past. While many candidates focus on "getting the wine right" the weighting of all marks across all papers allocated just 43% of the questions to identify region and/or grape variety. One can correctly identify most of the wines and still not earn a pass. Sound answers for quality and maturity questions (22% of all marks in this year's exams) are critical to success, as are questions covering method of production (20% of marks) and commercial position (15% of marks). As noted in each of the Paper Chairs reports, a lack of evidence from the glass to support an answer for identification, or absence of reasoned logic to argue different options is an ongoing concern.

A great number of high-quality wines were featured in the exam, but this was not always recognized by candidates, or they failed to adequately substantiate their answers with sound evidence from the glass, or used vague descriptions (good, very good, etc.). Many candidates neglected to compare and contrast with other wine(s) when asked to do so or seemed unsure how to approach such a question

especially when a large number of marks are allocated (for example, Paper 1, Question 2, Part [a] which was worth 36 marks). When dealing with a question of such importance, candidates should take their time and perhaps draft an outline that covers all aspects of the question before simply diving in to write their answer. Correct quality assessment is critical to becoming a Master of Wine and it is important to point out that you can earn full or passing marks for quality even when the wine is misidentified.

Surprisingly, too many method of production answers displayed a lack of theory knowledge or failed to earn full marks when key steps were omitted. It is often said that the Practical Exam is a theory exam with a tasting, thus candidates are advised to prepare for both parts of the exam. This is especially true for Paper 3 wines which invariably have a production technique question and one must simply know how to communicate these steps using evidence from the glass.

Commercial position responses seem better than in previous years, but too many answers focus mostly on venues and not enough discussion about price point, markets outside of the production area (or a candidate's home country) and competitive set. Full marks for commercial position can easily be earned by practice writing dry tasting notes and always relating one's answer to the style and quality of the wine.

Two more points. First, for questions relating to identification and quality, candidates are encouraged to write their conclusion at the top of each answer section. This makes it much easier for the examiner to follow your logic and record marks for valid evidence. Worse yet is when a candidate fails to draw a final conclusion, which leaves the examiner wondering and thus unable to award passing marks.

Secondly, with approximately one-third of the candidates handwriting the exam, nearly one-third of them have handwriting that can be classified as challenging, if not nearly impossible, to read. In some cases, this is because the candidate chose to write with a dull pencil thus making it difficult to discern some of the letters. When writing by hand, please use a sharp pencil or a pen with erasable ink. Interestingly, while 32 candidates handwrote the exam, 4 of the 8 passes were from candidates that wrote by hand. This is not enough scientific data to prove anything, except to say that fast typing is not always better (especially with numerous typos) and oftentimes less is more.

Finally, congratulations to our successful candidates, and to those may not have passed but have shown improvement or are close to passing. There are many possible reasons why the practical exam rate is less than the theory, but one thing is for certain. While theory knowledge can be gleaned from one's travel and reading, there is no substitute for tasting often and widely. Practice, practice, and more practice will make you a better taster, and don't forget your theory knowledge.

Paper one report: Paper Chair, Peter Mitchell MW

After a one-year break, the first tasting paper saw mixed results with many candidates having moments of excellence, but fewer sustaining that level over 4 questions.

As in every year, there were several candidates who did not finish the paper and I would re-iterate that failing to answer even one wine makes passing very unlikely. This year has seen the comment from examiners 'on course for a pass but did not finish' appear several times. It is better to write less and finish.

Approach each question in isolation and on its own merits. It appeared that several candidates had identified (wrongly as it turned out) a wine or variety in one question, so assumed for their next question that this was no longer an option to consider. It is always best to approach each flight without considering the others.

Once again there were many theory errors, especially regarding winemaking. There were also a number of papers with wine regions and grape varieties misspelt. These errors can cost marks and do not encourage the examiners to have confidence in a candidate's abilities.

Questions about market position are still not being answered fully. There were some colourful answers about likely venues to sell the wine, but not enough concentrated on the basics of price point and in which channel and in what markets the wine is likely to succeed in.

Whilst identification is a cornerstone of the exam, explaining how you got there is equally important, and the best candidates articulate their reasoning whilst also considering any possible options and why they are being discounted. Not only does this demonstrate your knowledge and abilities, but it also allows examiners to give you more credit if you take a wrong turn.

Quality was generally answered better this year, although several candidates have not taken heed of previous reports and continue to use 'good' or 'very good' without contextualisation.

Maturity answers were often lacking depth. For these questions it is vital to state how old the wine is, including a vintage if appropriate, where it is in its drinking evolution and whether it will improve further over time.

Many candidates are now typing their answers, but for those choosing to hand write, I would suggest checking that what you write in a hurry is legible to a third party. If it is hard to read, it is hard to mark.

Finally, there were a number of papers this year where candidates seemed to have mixed up the wine numbers when referring to them in their answer. Where possible examiners will try and work out which wine is being referred to, but I would urge all candidates to check for basic errors like this.

Question 1

This was an approachable opening question, and most candidates were correctly in France. For the majority this was the best answered question on the paper. Vin Jaune is a distinctive style and most candidates correctly identified the wine and its quality and maturity. This did also highlight those with gaps in theory knowledge regarding the style and how it is made. Most candidates correctly placed wine 2 in Burgundy. Whilst not opulent, the wine had a great deal of concentration and significant oak and the best candidates recognised this as Côte d'Or Premier or Grand cru quality, although few considered Corton-Charlemagne. The Rhône white was either answered very well or very poorly, perhaps illustrating a gap in some candidates' wine knowledge. Many clearly did not know what the wine was, but there were more marks available here for quality, maturity, and winemaking than for identification. This was a high-quality wine, which the majority picked up on, but having guessed the identity incorrectly, a lot of candidates then dropped marks by writing an answer for what they had guessed it was, rather than referring to the wine itself. The Pinot Gris was generally well answered, however there were those who either missed the residual sugar or wildly overstated it and a significant number who placed it in Vouvray, despite the moderate acidity.

Question 2

With three classic examples of the variety, this was somewhat surprisingly the least successfully answered question on the paper, however it did allow the best candidates to shine with a handful of excellent answers. Even for those not identifying the wines correctly, with nearly half of the marks available for comparing the quality and maturity good marks should still have been within reach, but many candidates failed to answer the question fully, missing discussing elements of one or more wines. A logical structure helps both the candidate and the marker in a question of this type.

The majority identified the Anjou as the most basic wine, but many candidates confused the Savennières with oak flavours and residual sugar where there were none.

Pinot Gris was the most common incorrect answer, often by those who had placed wine 4 as a Chenin Blanc and perhaps thought they had ticked off that variety. However, the acidity across the wines was too high for this to be plausible.

Question 3

The variety part was tackled reasonably well with the vast majority identifying Riesling; however, Austria was less well identified, with a significant number of candidates misreading both the alcohol

content and the residual sugar levels. Riesling is a classic variety with quite distinct regional styles and candidates need to be aware of these and present plausible arguments. For the second part of the question, candidates were asked to 'Compare and contrast' and too many did not do this or did not cover all of the parts, missing out on potential marks. There was a very clear quality difference between the two wines, and it was expected that candidates would discuss this and identify the better wine, but many did not.

Question 4

The examiners accepted that wine 12 might be more challenging to place, however wines 10 and 11 should have made identifying the country fairly straightforward and the majority of candidates managed this. Those who considered the USA and ended up in Australia still received some credit, however Italy, another common mistake, was less plausible and few marks could be gained. The Moscato was generally well answered as was the Chardonnay, although those who had gone for Italy found the Moscato to be higher quality than it was and contain far more CO₂ than it did, and they struggled to shoehorn the Chardonnay into an origin there. Even allowing considerable latitude for answers for the Pinot Gris, this was still the least successfully answered wine on the paper, with many candidates who had identified USA failing to consider wines from outside of California. This was a classic wine to funnel and demonstrate reasoning and tasting ability and the few that did this scored well.

Paper two report: Paper Chair, Lisa Perrotti-Brown MW

Paper 2 featured many well-known classic wines and was a good test of candidates' tasting abilities and theoretical knowledge. Candidates who were prepared performed very well as this paper had the highest overall marks across all three papers. Unfortunately, a number of candidates seemed to have been thrown off when asked about vintage, style, winemaking, and quality in the context of classic regions, let alone identifying those regions. It is essential to have a keen understanding of the wines of Bordeaux, Barbaresco, Southern Rhone, and Rioja, among others, as part of one's path to becoming a Master of Wine.

Question 1

This was a standard know-your-classics question with an emphasis on spotting quality within the context of the region and vintage. For this trio of Saint-Julien second growths, students needed to be in Bordeaux to pass the question. But it was disappointing how many students stopped at "Bordeaux" without going further to state a commune or communes. Given that the first part of the question asks, "identify the region as closely as possible," candidates are expected to home in on a commune. Marks were also gained by anyone who argued well for Pauillac, Margaux or even Pessac-Leognan.

Most marks for question 1 (20 marks per wine) were for identifying the vintage of each wine *and* its quality in the context of the region. This was clearly a two-part question, but some candidates did not answer the quality part of the question and therefore could only pick up half the allocated marks at most. In at least one case, a student failed this paper only because they completely neglected the second half of this question for all three wines.

For Bordeaux, "quality in the context of the region" will necessarily refer not only to intrinsic quality factors but the classification system of that region. For example, is it a classified growth from the Médoc? If so, what level? Etc. Very few stated that this was a trio of grand vins from the same 2eme cru chateau. Regardless, candidates could have passed the "quality in the context..." part of the question by arguing another classified growth level countered by the perceived vintage quality. Logical, well-constructed, and lucidly communicated thought processes garnered high marks.

Many students were off target with their assessment of Bordeaux vintages, most trying to guess the vintage by evaluating the state of maturity. Students needed to know that 2005 was a very tannic, classically great, slowly evolving vintage, 2013 was a weak vintage that is mature for the most part now, and that 2015 was an excellent, warmer, more generous year that is still very youthful. This part of the question effectively weeded out those candidates with too little tasting experience.

Question 2

This question, featuring a trio of single grape wines that are sometimes confused for one another - Pinot Noir, Nebbiolo, and Grenache - was generally well answered. Nearly everyone had "Pinot Noir" for wine number 1, while leeway was given for logical arguments for cool climate, New World regions apart from Sonoma Coast. Wine 5 - a benchmark Barbaresco - was another classic that revealed knowledge and experience gaps in those that missed it. Wine 6 was deemed by examiners as more demonstrative for its region, McLaren Vale, than its grape, Grenache, so marks were given for a range of red varieties that were well-argued. The most successful answers to the "style and commercial appeal" part of this question skillfully linked the organoleptic attributes of the wines to potential consumers and sales routes.

Question 3

Question three (wines 7 and 8) was designed to test candidates' skills in describing particular styles of wines and their consumer appeal, with most of the marks allocated to the compare and contrast part of the question. A few candidates tackled this very well, nailing the key attributes of each wine while weaving in elements such as commercial position and relative quality to address the types of consumers that might want to purchase these wines. Those who failed the question tended to try and shoehorn a style description that didn't fit onto one or both wines, or they largely ignored the consumer appeal part of the question, producing an oversimplified, rote answer that didn't accurately match the style.

Question 4

Surprisingly, the last two pairs of wines is where a lot of students suffered. These were classic regions/wines with a clear benchmark within each pair. A number of candidates were in Italy for the Rhone pair. More seemed to correctly identify Rioja for the second pair with wine 12 (Rioja Gran Reserva) a banker, but some ended up in Tuscany, Veneto, Burgundy, South Africa and Napa Valley. Still, identifying the region accounted for only a small proportion of the marks here. Thus, even if candidates completely missed what these wines were, they could have passed this portion of the exam by accurately describing what they tasted in terms of style, quality, method of production, commercial position, and ideal drinking window. Sadly, few did. Many invented attributes based on what they had decided the wine was, rather than simply describing what was in the glass. Even if candidates don't know the wine, they should trust their palates.

Paper three report: Paper Chair, Ulf Sjödin MW

Overall, the results from practical paper 3 were rather good, with many students being able to identify the origin of most of the wines. Many wines in the paper had very specific characteristics, and students who were able to identify sugar levels and alcohol levels did well on this paper.

However, the main purpose of this year's paper was to test the students' ability to recognise quality levels within the sparkling and fortified categories, and to connect evidence from the glass to different winemaking methods. In these aspects, the results were a little more disappointing.

Too many students failed to identify quality levels, even when wines of similar styles were tasted together, such as on questions 1 or 3. Students who underestimated the quality of wines 2 or 12 should really practice quality tastings much more, since the differences were substantial. It is understandable if quality levels are misjudged when you only have one wine to taste, but when two wines of similar origin and totally different quality levels are tasted together, the comparative quality levels should be obvious. This is crucial knowledge for an MW, and students who struggled with this usually failed the exam.

As usual, some students failed to communicate quality levels in an understandable way. One student used the phrase "good quality wine" for all twelve wines, yielding a lot of zero marks since there was no way that the examiners could understand the student's assessment of the wine. What the examiners are looking for is a judgement on the level of quality of the wine within the context of the type of wine considered. Is it a top-class wine from the region? Or a below average product? Students need to make sure that they can communicate the wine's position on the quality ladder in an understandable way.

Students should remember that the practical papers also require a lot of theoretical knowledge. Far too many students fail to communicate basic knowledge regarding production methods, especially for the fortified wines. All students must know how classic fortified or sweet wines are made and have reasonable knowledge on relevant sugar and alcohol levels, fermentation temperatures, and length of ageing of all common types of wines.

Questions on commercial position were generally answered well for all three questions, when the quality level was correct. Some students had a too narrow view of the market though, giving examples only from the on-trade, or only from their home market, but in general answers were good. Commercial position should be an easy task if you have the origin, quality and style identified, but some students lost marks even so. Some "dry tasting" is advised for everyone who has a problem with this.

Students should be careful not to make their lack of market knowledge too obvious to the examiners. Claims like “people in the Nordic countries consider fortified wines to have health benefits” don't signal much knowledge. Especially if the Paper Chair is from Sweden. A final advice regarding the structure of the answers: Students should try to communicate their answer in a logical order. If the question is about winemaking, it is a poor idea to write about malolactic before fermentation, oak ageing before crushing. A clear line of thought increases the chance of a perfect mark.

When the question asks for origin and grape variety, do not hide the answer in cryptic hints within the arguments. In some cases, it was hard to determine what answer the funneling ended up in, since arguments seemed to end with two or more options still considered. A wrong answer yields more marks than an answer that is unfinished, so whatever you do: Make a choice.

Question 1

There were three sparkling wines on question one, and some students managed to identify the first two wines as Champagne. There was, however, a tendency to put all wines in different regions. Students could get good marks for that, at least for wine 1, but it seemed that some students thought that they had to be from different regions, although there was no such hint in the question. Although funneling led to Champagne, they still went for England or Italy.

Production method was generally well answered. However, surprisingly few included blending, although the presence or absence of reserve wine characters were good arguments for the type of sparkling considered.

Question 2

This question required candidates to understand and recognise different production methods, which can include different grape varieties, techniques for achieving alcohol and sugar levels as well as the maturation process. Many students did very well on identifying the wines, although the method of production could be a problem for some. Some students mistook the vintage port for a lesser quality wine, and thus lost marks both on the quality question and the method of production, since these are closely linked.

Wine 5, the Brachetto d'Aqui, was a confusing wine for many students, and the examiners didn't expect everyone to be familiar with this type of wine. Some excellent answers were written though, even by students who clearly had never encountered this type of wine before. Those who managed to identify the very low alcohol level and the rather high sugar, describing a production method as “Asti style red wine”, could get a clear pass mark even if the origin was wrong.

Question 3

With two distinct types of Sherry and two Madeiras, an absolute majority of students managed to place the wines in the right regions. Those who didn't failed the whole paper, since it was hard to get more than basic marks if the origins were wrong. Students who made that mistake are advised to taste a lot more fortified wines before attempting the MW exam again.

Many students did very well on this question, and a few even seemed to know exactly which wines they had tasted. Others did rather well but failed to identify the types and quality levels within the region. The most difficult wine in terms of quality assessment was wine 10. Many students argued for a basic quality wine with the only argument that the wine was sweet. Just because the wine is sweet, does not mean it cannot be top quality; a wine of such length, complexity and concentration could hardly be an inexpensive supermarket cream sherry.